



NEWSLETTER

MARCH 2026

SPRING IS HERE.

As March unfolds, WAOW 2 continues to grow, piece by piece.

In this edition, we are delighted to introduce **Reto** through a **personal portrait**, share the timeless **beauty of diving** captured by **Julia Deville**, and take you back to the shipyard with the latest **construction progress from January and February 2026**.

We also invite you behind the scenes of craftsmanship, with a closer look at the **traditional tools and methods shaping WAOW 2**.

Happy reading!

RETO SCHLAEPFER

Originally from Basel in Switzerland, Reto brings a lifelong bond with the ocean and a global outlook to his role as Director of WAOW II. From the first stages of construction to future operations at sea, he leads the project with clarity and purpose. Having previously directed WAOW, it is both an honour and a deeply personal calling to shape her rebirth after her tragic loss — an experience he lived through on board. That moment did not weaken his commitment; it strengthened it. WAOW II is not only a new vessel, but a promise to carry forward a legacy and a community he holds close to his heart.



With over 25 years in the diving industry — including two decades in Indonesia — his journey has evolved from Divemaster and Instructor to Manager, Cruise Director, and Director. Built from experience on deck and at sea, his leadership combines operational expertise with a profound understanding of the people and places that make each voyage meaningful. Known for his sharp sense of humour and genuine humanity, he brings warmth and perspective to life on board, reminding everyone that excellence and kindness can sail together.



Graduated in Marine Environmental Science and trained in Marine Surveying, Reto unites technical knowledge with deep environmental respect. His vision for WAOW II is clear: a vessel crafted for exploration, safety, and sustainability — guided by resilience, dedication, and an unwavering passion for the ocean.

BEAUTY OF DIVING

This month, we felt the need to remind us of the beauty of the underwater world — endless blue, drifting light, vibrant reefs, and silent encounters that stay with us forever.

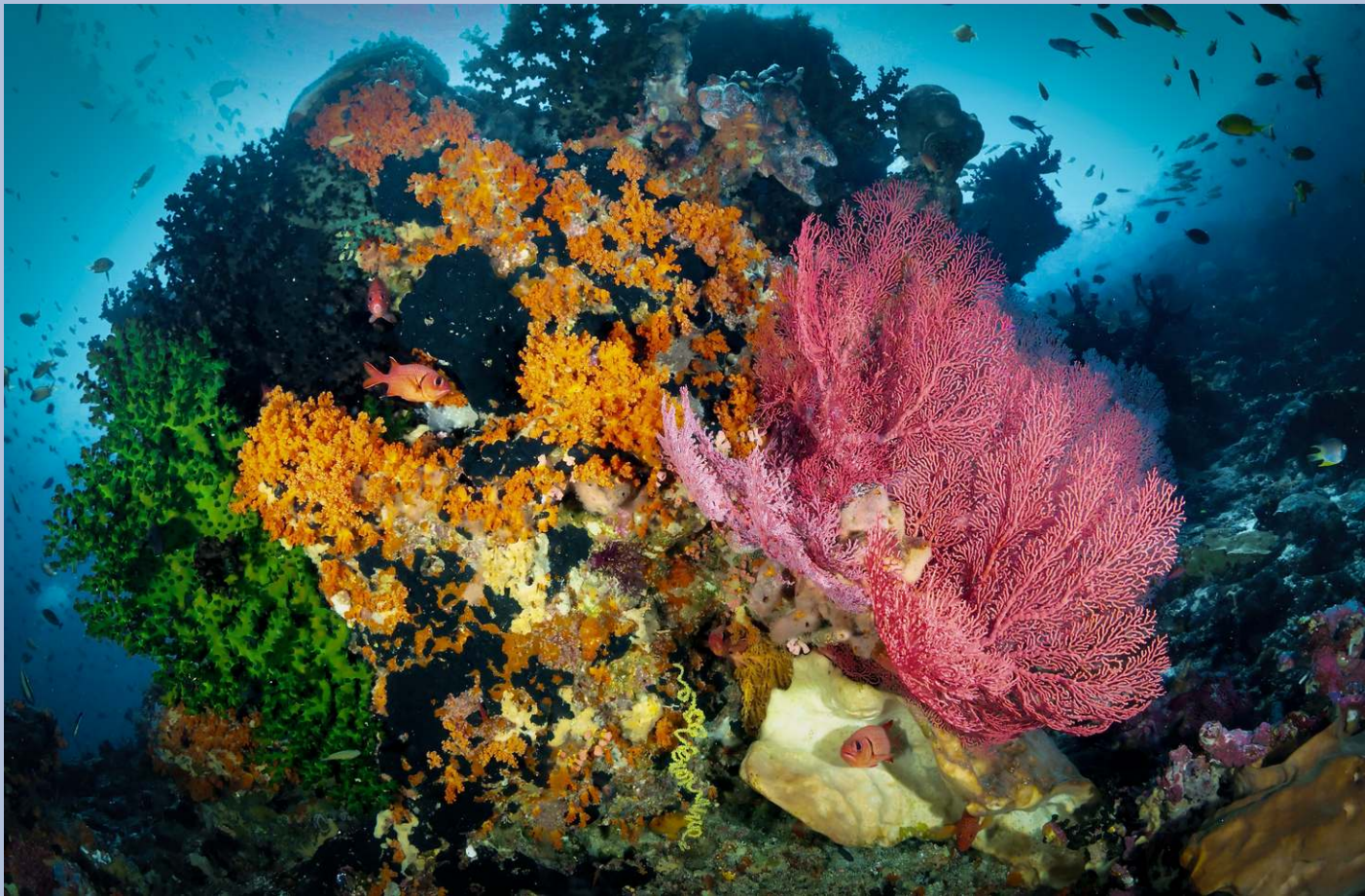
Beneath the surface is where WAOW's story truly begins.

It's where the deep connection we all share with the ocean was born — a love for exploration and for the vibrant life that calls it home.

It's that very same connection that unites us around WAOW 2 and its future adventures.

All pictures by Julia Deville, Ambon to Kaimana, 2023.

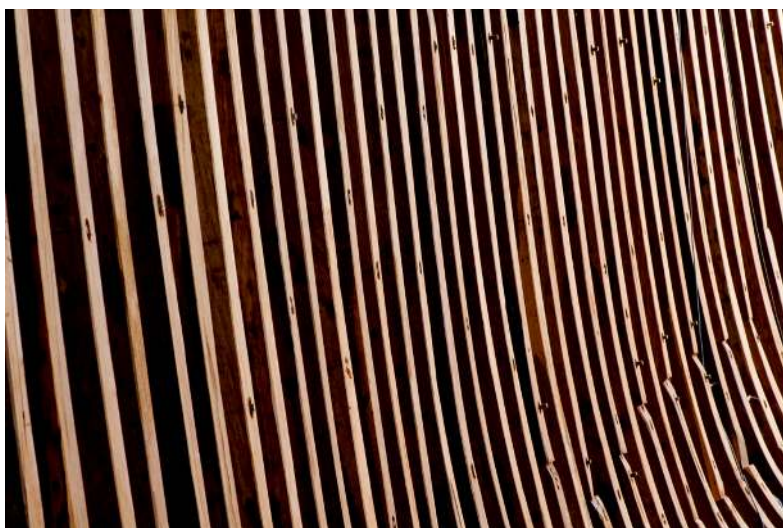


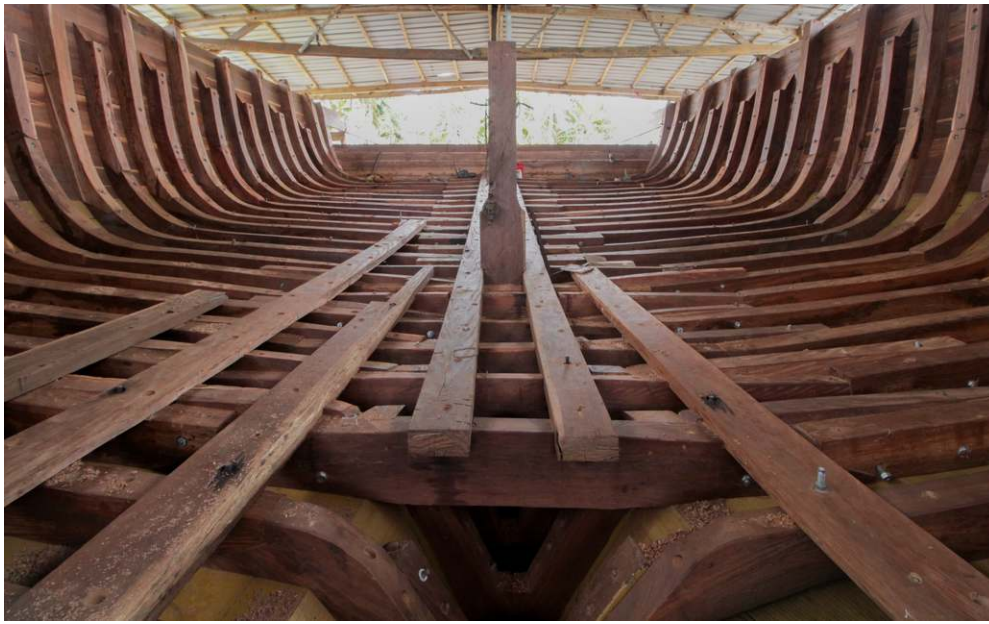




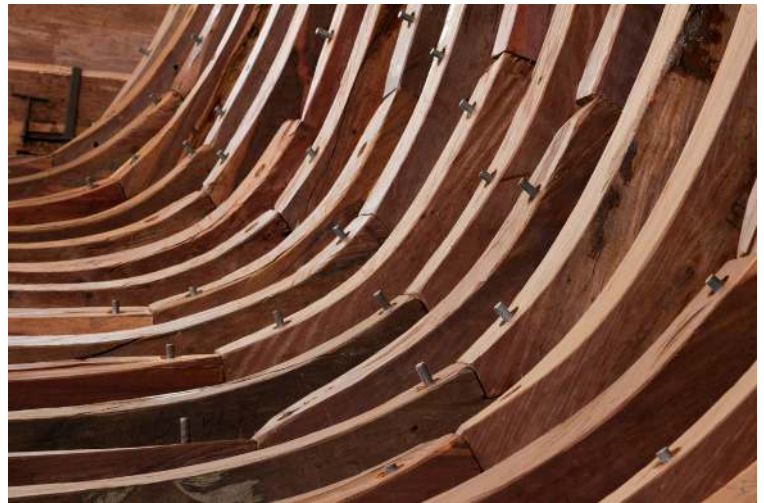
SHIPYARD VISIT

During our last visit in the shipyard last February the shipbuilders were installing the ribs, the curved frames that shape and strengthen the hull. Each frame is carefully adjusted and secured with large bolts passing through the keel structure.





At the same time, the keelson — a massive longitudinal beam placed above the keel — is being installed to lock the entire structure together and reinforce the vessel's backbone.

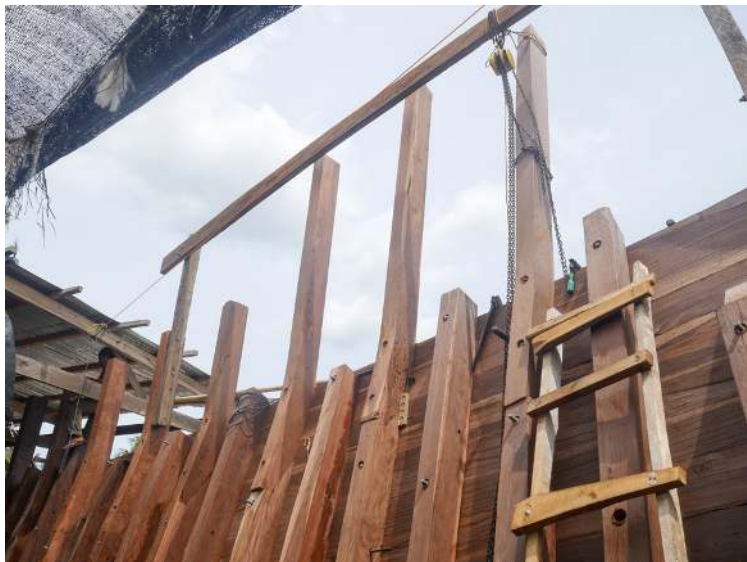


Work has also begun on the transom planking, where the single piece wooden boards are precisely shaped, aligned with treenails and fitted to follow the curves of the hull before being fastened with bolts.

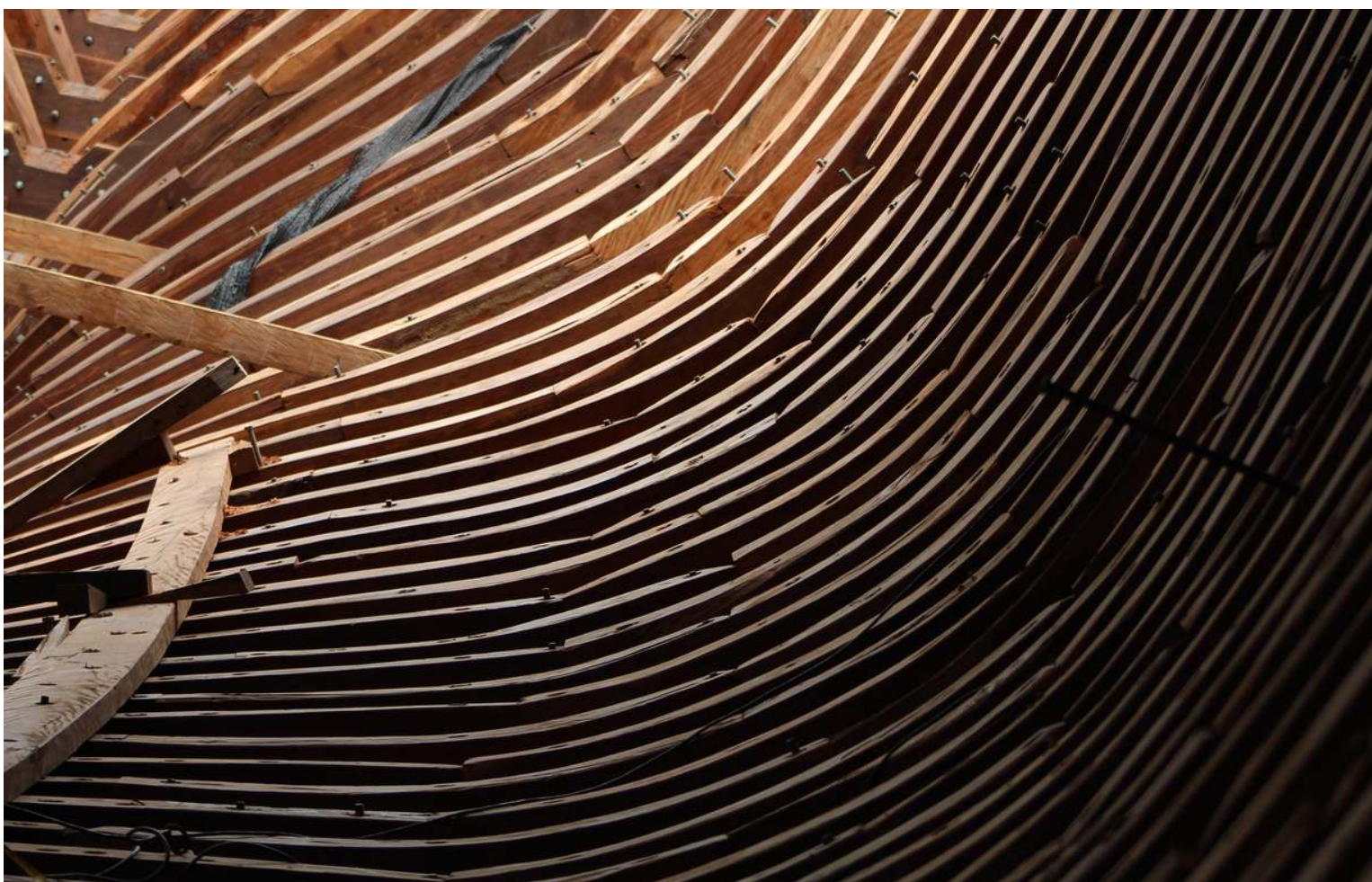




Meanwhile, the elevation of the bow has started, gradually raising the forward structure that will give the vessel its distinctive profile.



With every rib and plank added, WAOW 2's hull is steadily taking form.



TECHNICAL FOCUS: TOOLS

Every boat tells a story — but few reveal the tools that shape it.

At the WAOW 2 shipyard, centuries-old craftsmanship meets modern precision.

Here, the rhythm of wood, steel, and human hands comes alive through the tools that build her.

From the deep echo of traditional hammers to the sharp roar of chainsaws, each tool plays its part in transforming raw timber into a living vessel.

Some of the tools shaping WAOW 2:



1. Planes & chisels

Smoothing, shaping, and giving life to every wooden surface



2. Wooden mallets & iron hammers

Used to adjust frames, drive joints, and fine-tune every curve by hand



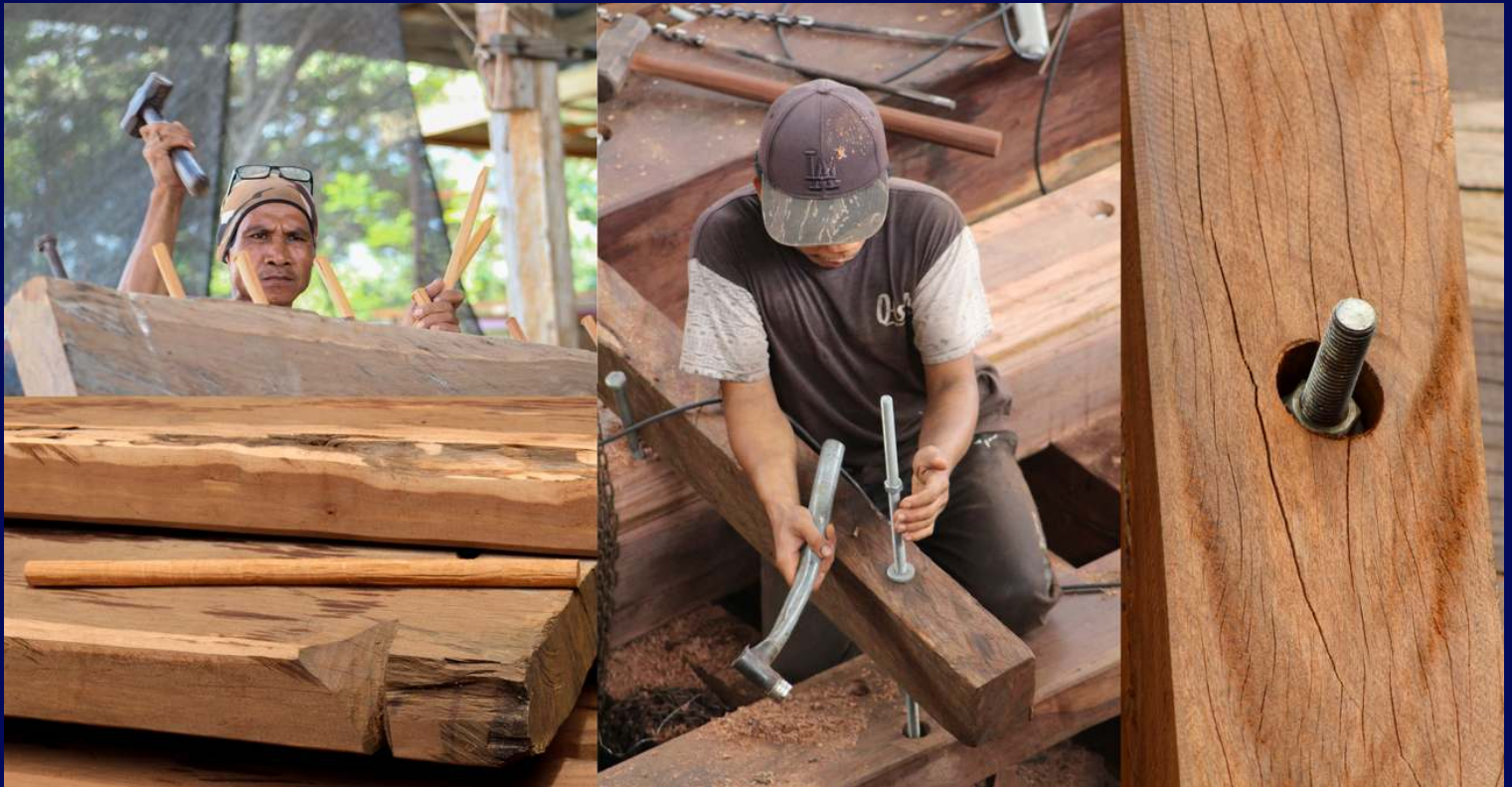
3. Hand saws & chainsaws

From fine cuts to shaping massive pieces, the chainsaws are handled here with remarkable precision, allowing for clean and controlled cuts.



4. Drills, long augers & palm leaves

To pierce through thick hardwood and prepare for structural assembly. After drilling the wood, dry palm leaves are used to mark the holes through the hull for the workers on the other side.



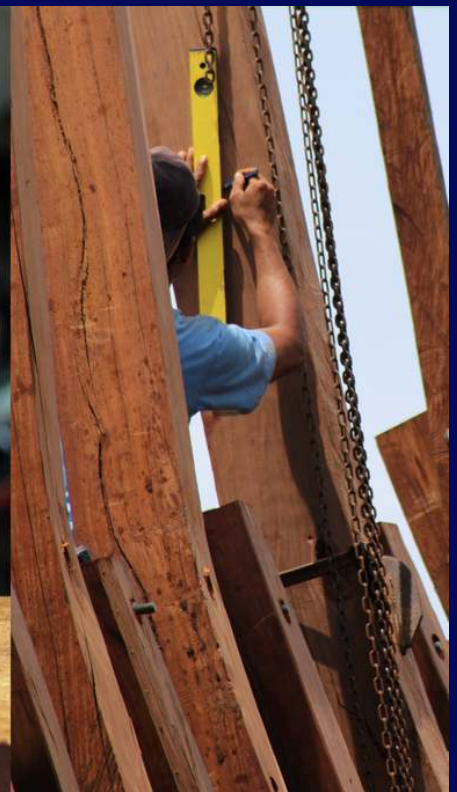
5. Treenails, bolts, nuts & threaded rods

The invisible strength holding ribs, keelson, and planking together



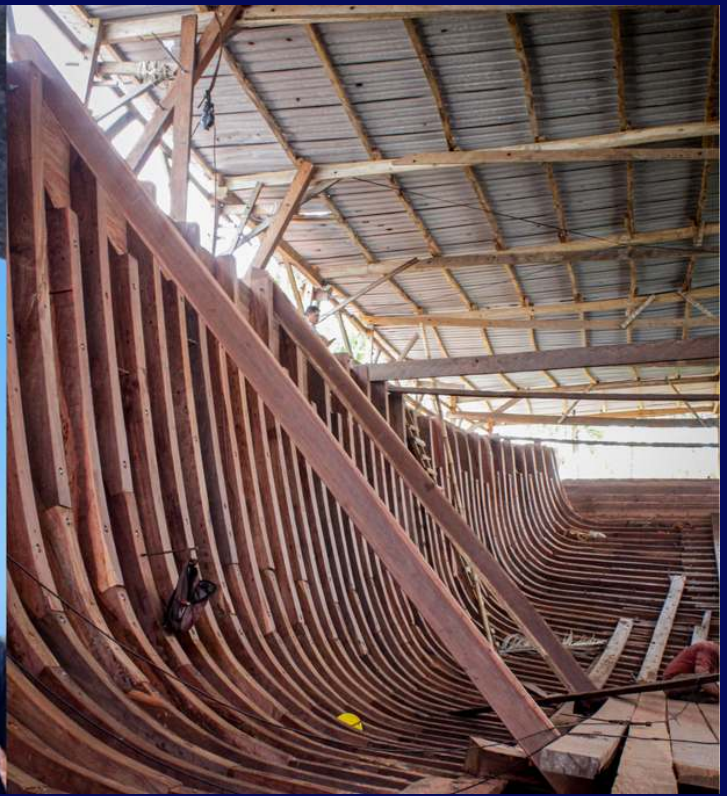
6. Wrenches & spanners

Tightening each connection with precision and care



7. Measuring lines, levels & chalk strings

Ensuring alignment without digital tools — just experience and a trained eye



8. Chainblocks, hoisting systems & "slide"

Lifting the heaviest pieces into place with controlled strength and sliding them down into the ship.



9. Tensioning systems

Holding, bending, and guiding the wood into its final form, some looking like big tweezers holding the wooden panes together.



10. Fire & water

Yes — even the elements themselves are tools, used to bend the wood and shape the hull.

No CAD. No automation. Only know-how, experience and an intimate understanding of wood and physics.

This is where tradition lives on — in every strike, every cut, every adjustment.

And slowly... WAOW 2 takes shape.

Watch more of these 10 tools used on WAOW 2's shipyard on our YouTube channel



THANK YOU FOR READING!
TAKE CARE!
WAOW team



Contact us at **info@waow.ch**
for full details on our participatory pre-sales
and their many advantages.



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